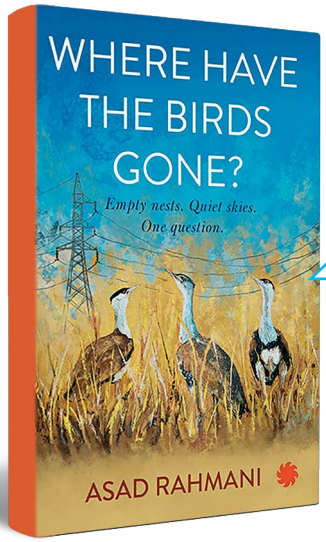


WHERE HAVE THE BIRDS GONE?
By Asad Rahmani
JUGGERNAUT
₹599; 360 pages

BOOKS

A SKY GROWING SILENT

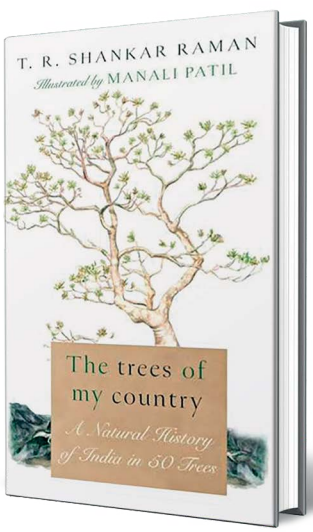
In *Where Have the Birds Gone?*, naturalist **Asad Rahmani** documents the plight of 14 threatened bird species from across India

There's nervous anticipation among members of Project Great Indian Bustard. In early October, the first lot of birds bred in captivity was released into the wild. These large birds once roamed Indian grasslands. About 120 struggle for survival in the wild today in two pockets of Rajasthan. Naturalist Asad Rahmani, former director of the Bombay Natural History Society, had seen it coming. It's a concern he reflects on in *Where Have the Birds Gone?*.

Over decades, Rahmani has spent long hours in the field and presents an engaging account. The 14 species he highlights come from across India and are connected by a common thread of dwindling natural habitat and a struggle for survival. Where the Manipur bush quail has gone missing in action for years now and the Jerdon's Courser makes its appearance every once in a while, others like the Greater Adjutant stork and the Indian skimmer have fared better.

The statistics Rahmani shares are alarming. Since 2012, the number of 'threatened' and 'near threatened' species have climbed from 153 to 203; as of 2025, 11.5 per cent of birds worldwide are threatened with extinction. Conservation programmes are a step forward. But the larger focus needs to be on preserving habitats. So that bird species that were once deemed 'common' remain just that. ■

—Shail Desai



THE TREES OF MY COUNTRY
A Natural History of India in 50 Trees
By T.R. Shankar Raman; Illustrated by Manali Patil
ALEPH BOOK COMPANY
₹1,499; 304 pages

BOOKS

The Citizenship of Roots

TREE BY TREE, here are 50 ways to discover India's precious green inheritance

One October afternoon, as the last gasp of the departing monsoon drenched Tamil Nadu's Anamalais, I shared an umbrella with a scientist who showed me a patch of rainforest that he and his team were trying to regenerate. It was here in Valparai that T.R. Shankar Raman introduced me to a magnificent tree whose name I had forgotten but whose presence remained etched in my memory.

I had come away feeling I had met a sentient being. Raman spoke with measured wisdom about the tree—no superlatives, only facts about its place in the forest, and how it nourishes a dozen or more species. I was left thinking: if this tree were to go extinct, what would become of this web of life?

When I got hold of Raman's new book, I was reacquainted with the name I had mislaid: *Culenia exarillata*, or Vedipla, as local people call it. It is one of 50 trees he describes. Not clinical like a field guide, this volume of essays strives for deeper kinship, treating the trees of our country as neighbours, family and fellow citizens. It ranges across India's geography from coastal mangroves to Himalayan highlands.

What distinguishes this isn't its sumptuousness but the realisation it leaves: without our inheritance of trees, we are an impoverished people. To truly encounter a tree, one must make a pilgrimage to the forest. To discover India through its trees, imagine how many such journeys await. How can one ever feel rootless in a land blessed with trees? ■

THIS VOLUME OF ESSAYS TREATS THE TREES OF OUR COUNTRY AS NEIGHBOURS, FAMILY AND FRIENDS

—Bijoy Venugopal